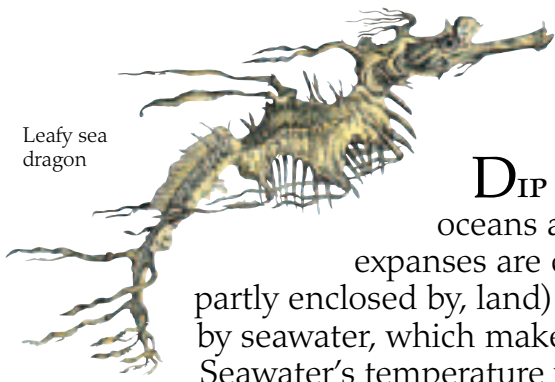
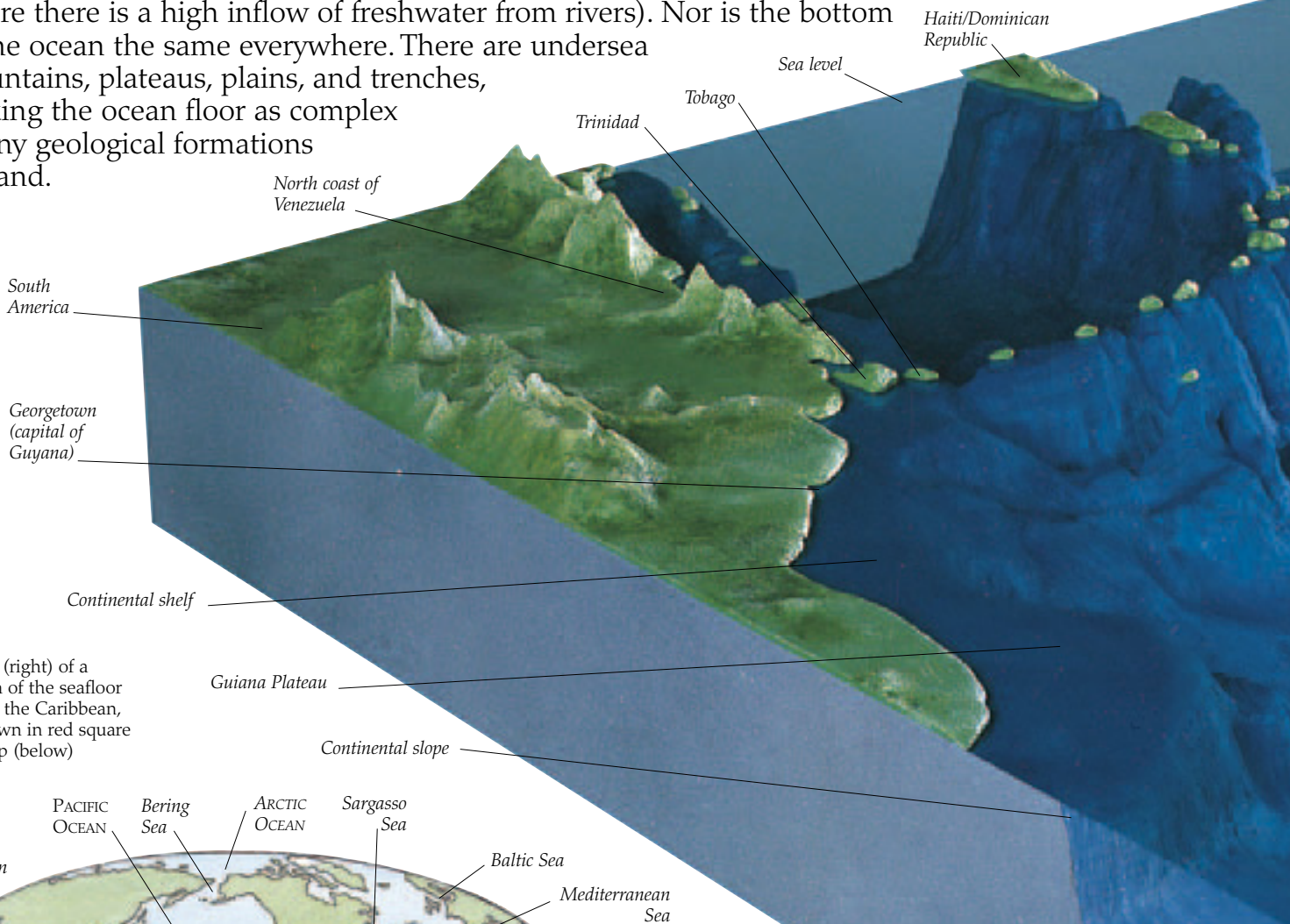


Oceans today

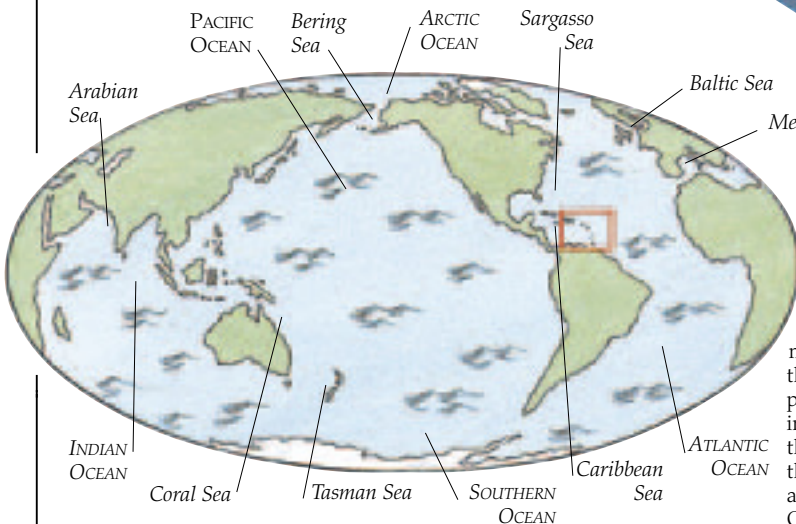
Leafy sea dragon



DIP A TOE IN ANY OCEAN and you are linked to all the world's oceans as the earth's seawater is one continuous mass. The largest expanses are called oceans while the smaller ones (usually close to, or partly enclosed by, land) are called seas. Two-thirds of the Earth's surface is covered by seawater, which makes up to 97 percent of the planet's entire water supply. Seawater's temperature varies in different areas—it is colder at the surface in polar regions than in the tropics. Generally, seawater gets colder with depth. Seawater's salinity varies from that of the saltiest waters (such as the desert-bound Red Sea where there is a high evaporation rate and little inflow of freshwater) to one of the least salty (the Baltic Sea where there is a high inflow of freshwater from rivers). Nor is the bottom of the ocean the same everywhere. There are undersea mountains, plateaus, plains, and trenches, making the ocean floor as complex as any geological formations on land.



Model (right) of a section of the seafloor east of the Caribbean, as shown in red square on map (below)



OCEANS OF OCEANS

The world's five oceans, ranging from the largest to the smallest, are the Pacific, Atlantic, Indian, Southern, and Arctic. The Pacific Ocean, by far the largest, covers 59 million sq miles (153 million sq km) and is about 13 times the size of the Arctic Ocean. The Arctic Ocean's center is permanently covered by a layer of sea ice that grows larger in winter and shrinks in summer by melting. Over half the Southern Ocean is also frozen in winter and sea ice still fringes the continent of Antarctica during the summer. The average depth of all the oceans is 12,000 ft (3,650 m) with the deepest part in the Pacific Ocean at 36,201 ft (11,034 m) in the Mariana Trench, east of the Philippines.